

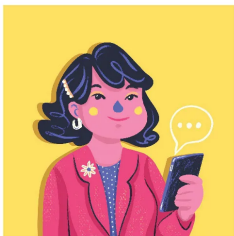
Persona Creation for Software Requirements Elicitation

Using the Empathize, Define, Ideate Framework

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What is it?



Sarah Santiago

Age: 34

Education: Accounting certificate

Location: Arlington, VA

Family: Divorced, has 11 and 13 girls ½ time & 2 cats

Occupation: Supply Chain Manager

“Results are really important to me – at work and in the garden. I don’t like to waste my time.”

Goals

- To make the most of free time and create memories with kids.
- To grow enough herbs and vegetables to cook with all summer- and some pretty flowers!
- Support local businesses & shop organic.

Frustrations

- Sometimes the seeds I've planted don't turn out like they're supposed to. What am I doing wrong?
- I usually only have 15 minutes to browse my phone. I want to be able to save and shop later.

Sarah is a busy mom. She works a demanding job and has two daughters. Coordinating schedules and running a household take up a lot of time. She finds gardening relaxing. She tries to get the most out of her limited time, growing vegetables and flowers that don't require too much special care. If plants don't grow right, she gets frustrated. Shopping online for seeds is convenient, but she wants to make sure she gets quality and supports local businesses. She likes simple apps that allows her to compare, research, and save items to buy later.

What is a User Persona?

- A fictional, yet realistic, representation of a key segment of your users
- Created from real data: interviews, surveys, and research
- Transforms abstract user data into relatable, memorable profiles
- Guides software requirements and design decisions
- **Not based on assumptions or stereotypes**

Why Personas? Connecting to the UX Process

- Personas are not just a deliverable—they are a **tool for thinking**
- They help us move systematically through core UX stages:
 - **Empathize**: Deeply understand real users and their needs
 - **Define**: Clearly articulate user problems and goals
 - **Ideate**: Generate solutions grounded in real user contexts
- **Result**: User-centered requirements that solve real problems

Empathize: Building User Understanding

- **Purpose:** Step into users' shoes and see their world
- **How Personas Help:**
 - Synthesize interview data into relatable characters
 - Prevent designing for ourselves or a "generic user"
 - Build team empathy for real user frustrations and motivations
 - Make user needs memorable and actionable
- **Without Personas:** Teams make assumptions based on their own experiences
- **With Personas:** Decisions grounded in real user evidence

Define: Focusing on Real Problems

- **Purpose:** Turn insights into clear, actionable problem statements
- **How Personas Help:**
 - Identify and prioritize the most important user needs
 - Craft focused problem statements (e.g., "Sarah needs to quickly save plants for later purchase")
 - Keep requirements specific and user-centered
 - Prevent feature creep and scope drift
- **Result:** Requirements that are relevant, testable, and valuable

Ideate: Creating Targeted Solutions

- **Purpose:** Brainstorm solutions that truly address user needs
- **How Personas Help:**
 - Inspire creative ideas tailored to real user scenarios
 - Act as a "reality check" for proposed features
 - Support feature prioritization based on user value
 - Guide user story creation and acceptance criteria
- **Key Question:** "Does this solution help one of our personas achieve their goals?"

Key Components of a Strong Persona

- **Name and Photo:** Make them human and memorable
- **Headline/Descriptor:** One-sentence summary of their main trait
- **Demographics:** Age, location, job title, education
- **Background/Story:** Context about their work and experiences
- **Goals and Objectives:** What they want to achieve
- **Motivations:** What drives them? Hopes and fears?
- **Challenges and Pain Points:** Current obstacles and frustrations
- **Behaviors and Preferences:** How they interact with tools
- **User Scenario:** Example of how they'd use your software
- **Quote:** Direct insight from real user research

5-Step Persona Creation Process

- ① **Gather and Review User Data** (Empathize)
- ② **Identify Patterns and Segment Users** (Empathize)
- ③ **Draft Persona Profiles** (Define)
- ④ **Refine and Validate** (Define)
- ⑤ **Use Personas in Requirements** (Ideate)

Steps 1-2: Empathize Phase

Step 1: Gather and Review User Data

- Use interview transcripts, survey responses, observations
- Look for recurring themes, goals, frustrations, behaviors

Step 2: Identify Patterns and Segment Users

- Group users by common characteristics
- Look for shared goals, similar pain points, comparable workflows
- Each cluster becomes the foundation for a persona

Steps 3-4: Define Phase

Step 3: Draft Persona Profiles

- Fill out the persona template for each user segment
- Ensure every detail ties back to real research data
- Make each persona distinct and specific

Step 4: Refine and Validate

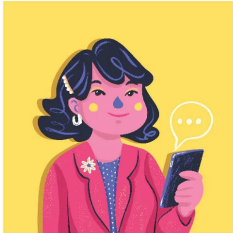
- Check that personas are evidence-based, not stereotypes
- Ensure each persona represents a meaningful user segment
- Share drafts with stakeholders for feedback

Step 5: Ideate Phase

Use Personas in Requirements Elicitation

- Reference personas when defining software requirements
- Ask: "Does this feature solve a real problem for one of our personas?"
- Use personas to write user stories: "As [Persona], I want [goal] so that [benefit]"
- Prioritize features based on persona value and impact
- Test ideas against persona scenarios

Example Personas



Sarah Santiago

Age: 34
Education: Accounting certificate
Location: Arlington, VA
Family: Divorced, has 11 and 13 girls ½ time & 2 cats
Occupation: Supply Chain Manager

“Results are really important to me – at work and in the garden. I don’t like to waste my time.”

Goals

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Frustrations

- Sometimes the seeds I’ve planted don’t turn out like they’re supposed to. What am I doing wrong?
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Sarah is a busy mom. She works a demanding job and has two daughters. Coordinating schedules and running a household take up a lot of time. She finds gardening relaxing. She tries to get the most out of her limited time, growing vegetables and flowers that don’t require too much special care. If plants don’t grow right, she gets frustrated. Shopping online for seeds is convenient, but she wants to make sure she gets quality and supports local businesses. She likes simple apps that allows her to compare, research, and save items to buy later.

From Persona to Requirements: Sarah's Example

Persona Insight: Sarah has only 15 minutes to browse and wants to save items for later

Defined Problem: Busy users need efficient browsing and shopping tools

Ideated Solutions:

- Quick search and filter functionality
- Save/wishlist feature for later purchase
- One-click add to cart from saved items
- Local business integration and availability indicators
- Mobile-optimized interface for quick browsing

User Story: "As Sarah, I want to quickly save plants to a wishlist so that I can research and purchase them later when I have more time."

Example Personas (continued)



Bill Miller

Age: 55
Education: B.S. in Human Nutrition
Location: Virginia Beach, VA
Family: Long term partner, Louis, and 2 Yorkies
Occupation: Nutrition Counselor

"I like planning my garden as much as I do growing it! My yard is my happy place."

Goals

- For him and Louis to enjoy the beautiful yard.
- To find new and interesting plants to challenge himself and impress friends.
- To relax and enjoy the process of planning and researching.

Frustrations

- When the garden center is busy, I feel rushed. I want to take my time comparing seeds.
- Staring at a phone screen hurts my eyes.
- Shopping online is confusing. How do I find what I want?

Bill lives at a comfortable pace with his partner Louis and their two beloved dogs. He takes a lot of pride in his yard and spends evenings and weekends tending his many plants. He is a very experienced gardener and like to grow all kinds of things. He only buys heirloom & organic. He enjoys researching and reading catalogs. Shopping for seeds can be a pain - the stores can be busy and loud, or have limited variety. Online shopping is tough too - bright screens and small type hurt his eyes. He's not tech savvy and sometimes websites and apps confuse him.

From Persona to Requirements: Bill's Example

Persona Insight: Bill finds phone screens hurt his eyes and online shopping confusing

Defined Problem: Users with visual sensitivity need accessible, easy-to-use interfaces

Ideated Solutions:

- High contrast mode and adjustable text size
- Simple, clear navigation with large buttons
- Detailed plant information with high-quality images
- Step-by-step guided shopping process
- Print-friendly catalog views

User Story: "As Bill, I want adjustable text size and high contrast options so that I can comfortably browse plant information without eye strain."

Assignment Instructions

Task: Create 8 personas for your assigned project

Requirements:

- Base personas strictly on your interview data—no assumptions
- Each persona must include all key components
- Follow the 5-step process (Empathize → Define → Ideate)
- Use personas to identify at least 3 software requirements per persona

Deliverable: 8 complete hand-drawn persona profiles that will guide your requirements elicitation

AI Usage: There is no restrictions, **but the deliverables must be hand-drawn**

Summary: Personas in the UX Process

- **Empathize:** Personas build empathy by humanizing user data
- **Define:** Personas focus problem definition on real needs
- **Ideate:** Personas inspire and validate solution ideas
- **Impact:** User-centered requirements that solve real problems
- **Remember:** A well-crafted persona is your compass for effective software design

- Coursera: Start the UX Design Process
- Medium: Creating User Personas for Google's UX Design Certificate